

LEADER OF THE SOVIET UNION Born 1878 Died 1953

Joseph Stalin

“I believe in one thing only,
the power of human will.”

JOSEPH STALIN

The future dictator of the Soviet Union was born in 1878 in Georgia, in the southeastern Russian Empire. Joseph Dzugashvili (not yet “Stalin,” or “Man of Steel”) attended a theological college in the Georgian capital, Tblisi, where he became involved in radical politics. He joined the Marxist Social Democratic Labor Party (SDLP), and with Lenin sided with the Bolshevik faction (see p.377) when the SDLP split in 1904.

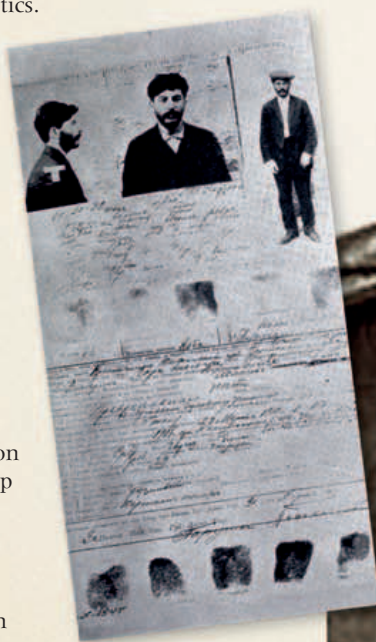
Many Russian Marxists, including Lenin (see pp.376–77) were forced to live in exile, devoting themselves to complex theoretical debates. In Russia, Stalin engaged in practical subversive activities, ranging from armed robbery to distributing illegal pamphlets. His efforts attracted the attention of both the Bolshevik leadership and the police. After several arrests, Stalin was facing exile in Siberia when he was unexpectedly freed after the overthrow of the Czar in March 1917 (see pp.376–77).

Rise to power

Stalin proved himself a tough enforcer of Lenin’s policies during the upheavals that brought the Bolsheviks to power in 1917 and the Civil War that followed. Hard-working and devious, once the Soviet Union was established he became one of the most powerful men in the country. In 1922 Stalin was appointed General Secretary to the Central Committee of the Communist Party. He exploited this post to fill Party positions with his appointees and expel his enemies. Lenin belatedly turned against Stalin, calling for someone “more tolerant... more polite.” But by then, Stalin’s hold was too strong. Stalin’s maneuvering after Lenin’s death in January 1924 was a masterly exercise in political manipulation. He

Father of the people

Stalin’s official portrait of 1940 is intended to suggest his farsighted wisdom. The photograph shows no sign of the smallpox scars that disfigured him from childhood.



Information card

Stalin was arrested several times before 1917. This is a police record of one of his crimes. The future dictator was photographed and his fingerprints were recorded.



pitted his rivals for power against one another, then used his control of the Party to ensure that it expelled or demoted them. By the time Leon Trotsky—once fellow Bolshevik and now bitter rival—was exiled from the Soviet Union in 1929, Stalin had established himself as the country’s undisputed leader.

In an early example of his taste for rewriting the past, Stalin celebrated his 50th birthday that year, discreetly adjusting his birth date to 1879. The celebrations initiated the personality cult that was to continue for the rest of

his life. Hailed by his propagandists as “the Universal Genius” and the “Man of Steel,” factories, towns, and even mountains were named after him across the Soviet Union, and every reference to him was couched in terms of groveling flattery (see pp.380–81).

Socialism in one country

In 1924, Stalin proposed the slogan “Socialism in One Country.” In practice, this meant building up the power of the Soviet Union, the one country where Marxist revolution had succeeded. Stalin was acutely

conscious of Russia’s economic and cultural backwardness, and he despised the peasant majority. His successor, Nikita Khrushchev, wrote: “for Stalin, the peasants were scum.” From 1928–29, Stalin aimed to transform the Soviet Union into a major international power, and the process of the collectivization of agriculture and industrialization (see p.380–81) reflected his belief in the use of terror to achieve radical change. During the 1930s, millions of Soviet citizens were killed by the state, used as slave labor in prison camps, or died in famines to